7. Honesty

Truth can be toxic in international sport, if expressed thoughtlessly. Emotion is a potentially dangerous commodity if it is unchecked in a team meeting and criticism becomes personal. Yet, when the alternative is deception, wilful ignorance of broken relationships and collective weaknesses, the risks are worthwhile.

We did not know it at the time, but the Honesty Meeting, called immediately after we had been bowled out by the West Indies for 51 to lose by an innings and twenty-three runs in Jamaica in February 2009, marked the moment England's ascent to being the best team in world cricket began. It was harsh, horrible at times, but cleansing in its candour.

Andy Flower and Andrew Strauss, a new head coach and captain appointed on an interim basis, had every right to be livid after a terrible performance in their first Test in charge. There could be no hiding place, no room for self-deception, since defeat exposed divisions and demanded a fundamental change in approach and attitude.

It was probably the first time I had spoken with true honesty and openness in such a situation. It could have developed into a free-for-all, because some people had been bitching about others being more interested in haircuts, cars and clothes than serious training, but I felt it was time to make a simple statement of fact and commitment.

I was very emotional, on the edge at times, but tried to be rational. I acknowledged I hadn't been scoring enough runs for England. I'd been out for thirties and forties, and hadn't scored a hundred in fourteen months.